DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

Why Does God Hide His Face, and How Will It End?

Daat Tevunot §40

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** §40 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Thursday 10 November 2022

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Review: why yihud Hashem allows evil

The class was dedicated to the memory of a member of the community. The Rabbi began mid-§40 and asked a participant to summarise. The purpose of creation is to bestow good, and yihud Hashem is how it is done. Unity is known by negation, so there has to be bad to negate. If God revealed His positive attributes, there would be no room for bad; with no bad there would be no free will, and the purpose of creation, that we choose the good and make it our own, would fall away. Yihud Hashem also includes all the other attributes in negative form: there is no one compassionate like Him.

Asked which comes first, the Rabbi said his reading of the book is that the primary purpose is bestowing good, and yihud Hashem is the means. If God did not want to bestow good, He would not need to reveal His unity.

A new aspect had been introduced before: evil must be banished at some point. It is transient and serves a purpose, a "mum over," a passing blemish. Since evil comes from God's concealment, when there is full illumination again, evil will vanish automatically and yihud Hashem will be revealed.

The root of evil is concealment

Going back a page, the Rabbi read: the root of all evil is God's concealment. Had He fully illuminated Himself, everything would be complete. Instead He hid His face and left us somewhat deficient. Illumination is life; concealment is the source of evil.

But the purpose of concealment is not concealment. God hid so that bad could exist and so that we would reveal Him ourselves, clearing away the evil that the concealment produced. How? By turning away from the bad, through Torah and misvot. The Rabbi recalled his image from a previous class of a beam or pillar of light: you bring yourself into the beam, and the evil disappears. By doing so you declare that all the bad in the world is a facade, not real; you attribute everything back to God and reveal His unity. "Mission accomplished": yihud Hashem is revealed, we did it ourselves, the good is now part of us, and God's purpose of bestowing good is complete.

The reward of a misvah

The Ramhal calls these the laws that a person does "and lives by them," the hidden, eternal life. The Rabbi returned to "sekhar misvah misvah": the reward of a misvah is the misvah itself, because by doing it we take godliness and goodness into ourselves, and that is the closeness God concealed for us to find.

A participant noted the common reading that the reward of a misvah is another misvah. The Rabbi said both interpretations are true, but warned against the attitude of some religious people who treat Torah and misvot as collecting points so that God will wipe away their sins and admit them to Gan Eden. What is Gan Eden? "That's a big, big question." Another participant suggested that each misvah reveals God's oneness, and that this is itself the reward. The Rabbi liked it and added two teachings of the Kedushat Levi (of Berditchev): - "Tenu oz lElokim," give strength to God: as if God wants us to give Him strength by doing misvot. - In Dayenu, "kamah maalot tovot laMakom aleinu" can be read as how many good things there are "for God" when He does good to us: when we allow Hashem to do good to us, we do Him a favour.

If we do not do it, it will happen anyway

God will not hide His face forever. If we do not reveal the unity through our own work, it will reveal itself; the wicked will either return or perish. That is the meaning of the verse "beittah ahishenah," in its time I will hasten it, as the Gemara explains. "In its time": yihud Hashem must be revealed one day. "I will hasten it": we can bring it closer.

The end of free will

Once yihud Hashem is revealed, free choice ends, and with it the years of service. With no concealment there is no bad, and with no bad there is no choice. The choice we have every moment between good and bad exists only for as long as God decides is needed for everyone to have a chance: to see who will be righteous, who will repent, and who will perish. That is the period of 6,000 years. After it, human beings will no longer have bodies with base, animal instincts; they will be stripped of materialism and of everything that flows from the yeser hara.

Even in the days of Mashiah, the verse says, "I have no desire in them": full free will is already disappearing as the unity begins to show. The Rabbi reminded the group that Mashiah is the end of this world, a prelude, while olam haba is this world refined. If Mashiah came tonight, by the count there would be 217 years left until 6,000.

A participant asked about Derech Hashem, which says that in the days of Mashiah we can still grow closer to God. The Rabbi said that then the choice is no longer between good and bad but between "good and gooder," like going from a first-class degree to a double first. After 6,000 there is no development at all.

Bodies or souls?

Asked whether we will have bodies, the Rabbi first said the Ramhal speaks here of being stripped of materialism, then corrected himself: the Ramhal follows the Ramban, that the soul refines the body completely. As Derech Hashem says, it is not fair that the body that toiled

should not share in the reward, but it will be an elevated, lofty body, not the animal body we have now. The Rambam holds that the world to come is souls alone. The Rabbi said he has always found that hard: why raise the dead only for them to die again? A participant suggested that at 6,000 they transition rather than die, which the Rabbi said would work, though the Rambam does not say so.

God behind the storm

The paragraph ends by showing God's great power. "You have to be really powerful to see bad thrown in your face and to keep quiet." He lets the world run like a storm, "soer," while evil rules and spreads. People can sink to the lowest level and He does not destroy the world; He is watching and in full control.

The Ramhal calls this a strong pillar of faith: we should never despair over the length and difficulty of the exile, because it must end, and God is the one behind the storm. The key line: the more evil in the world, the greater the revelation; the deeper the trouble, the greater the salvation. A participant noted that golah (exile) and geulah (redemption) differ by a single letter, an aleph.

The Rabbi distinguished two kinds of bad: the bad that happens to the world, such as natural disasters, and the bad the world does, our sins, where we forget for a moment that the enticement is not really bad. He thought the Ramhal here refers mainly to the troubles we go through, and said both take us away from yihud Hashem. More next week.

Summary

- The root of evil is God's concealment, but its purpose is that we reveal Him ourselves through Torah and misvot.
- Revealing His unity completes God's purpose of giving good; "sekhar misvah misvah," the misvah is its own reward.
- If we do not reveal it, it will reveal itself in its time; we can hasten it.
- When yihud Hashem is revealed, evil and free will end; this is the 6,000-year span, with free will already fading in the days of Mashiah.
- God's restraint in the storm is a pillar of faith: the deeper the exile, the greater the redemption.

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